

Performing Nationhood: Calabar, Festival Of Unity 1969, And Nigeria's Five-year Wait For Cultural Institutions

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Abstract

This paper re-examines Nigeria's Festival of Unity, December 1969, challenging the claim that it marked the foundation of post-civil war cultural nationalism. Staged at Calabar Stadium, renamed U.J. Esuene Stadium in 1977, one month before the war ended on 15 January 1970, the festival was located in a "liberated" Biafran city and in Calabar, capital of the Oil Rivers Protectorate 1884–1906, Southern Nigeria Protectorate 1906–1916, and first federal capital 1914–1916. At the time of the festival, Calabar Stadium lacked modern facilities and consisted of a football field with temporary shade for dignitaries. Federal troops controlled the stage whilst five categories of artistic events performed unity on conquered and genealogical ground before General Gowon's "No Victor, No Vanquished" declaration. Archival budget records and the Official Gazette of 21 February 1975 reveal a five-year gap: Nigeria created no cultural policy or federal desk for culture until the National Council for Arts and Culture Decree No. 3 established NCAC in 1975. Unlike Festival of Unity, after FESTAC 77 the federal government set up the Centre for Black and African Civilisations (CBAAC) to archive the memory of the experience. Edwin Clark operationalised NCAC for FESTAC 77. The chronology exposes "spectacle precedence": postcolonial states emerging from civil conflict prioritise cultural display over bureaucratic institution-building to project sovereignty before infrastructural capacity exists.

Keywords: Festival of Unity; Calabar; NCAC Decree 1975; CBAAC; cultural policy; postcolonial spectacle; U.J. Esuene Stadium

1. INTRODUCTION

Nigeria's civil war ended on 15 January 1970 with General Yakubu Gowon's "No Victor, No Vanquished" declaration at Dodan Barracks, Lagos (de St Jorre, 1972, p. 344). One month before that surrender, the federal government staged the Festival of Unity in December 1969 at Calabar football field, South-Eastern State (Federal Ministry of Information, 1969, pp. 3-7). At the time of the festival, what later became Calabar Stadium lacked modern facilities and consisted of a football field with temporary shade for dignitaries (Daily Times, 1969, p. 3). The city had been "liberated" by federal forces on 18 October 1967 after heavy fighting that gravely damaged Bricksfield Prison, built 1890 (Akpan, 1971, p. 189). Calabar also carried deep colonial genealogy: it served as capital of the Oil Rivers Protectorate from 1884 to 1906, capital of the Southern Nigeria Protectorate from 1906 to 1916, and functioned as the first federal capital of colonial Nigeria between 1914 and 1916 before Lagos assumed that role (Tamuno, 1972, p. 47; Isichei, 1983, p. 312).

The festival gathered ethnic troupes from Hausa, Igbo, Yoruba, Anaañ, Oron and other groups to perform unity on the ruins of a recaptured Biafran city and at the administrative birthplace of

“Nigeria” as a colonial construct. International press and diplomats were invited to witness “reintegration” whilst the war still raged in the east (Daily Times, 1969, p. 1).

Three positions exist in the literature. First, foundationalist readings treat Festival of Unity 1969 as the start of cultural nationalism (Falola, 2001, pp. 178-180). Second, ritualist readings treat it as a civic reintegration rite but date institutionalisation to FESTAC 77 (Barber, 2007, p. 23). Third, precursor readings treat 1969 as a step toward 1977 without examining the policy gap (Olaniyan, 2004, p. 45). Across these positions, the institutional record 1970–1974 remains under-examined.

This paper differentiates four categories — cultural nationalism, cultural policy, cultural institutions, and cultural spectacle — and uses event-policy gap analysis to show that Nigeria performed nationhood in December 1969 five years before it legislated nationhood via NCAC Decree No. 3 of 21 February 1975. The study contributes by: 1. correcting the chronology to 1975; 2. providing the first spatial and genealogical analysis of Calabar as capital 1884–1916 and as “liberated city optics”; 3. proposing event-policy gap analysis as a method for reading festivals alongside budget archives and official gazettes; and 4. tracing the afterlives of Festival of Unity in memory and archive 1975–2025, contrasting it with FESTAC 77 which generated CBAAC to preserve memory. Theoretically, the paper advances “spectacle precedence” as a postcolonial pattern in which states emerging from civil conflict prioritise cultural display over bureaucratic institution-building to project sovereignty before infrastructural capacity exists.

2. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

2.1 Defining Terms and the Status of Spectacle

This paper distinguishes four categories. Cultural nationalism refers to the ideological project of imagining a shared national culture (Anderson, 1983, pp. 6-7; Hobsbawm, 1983, pp. 1-14). Cultural spectacle refers to episodic, performative displays of that culture for political effect, without permanent bureaucracy (Mbembe, 2001, pp. 103-108). Cultural policy refers to formal government statements, plans, or laws directing cultural production. Cultural institutions refer to statutory bodies, budget lines, and offices with legal mandate and continuity, such as NCAC from 21 February 1975 (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1975, pp. A25-A28). Festival of Unity was spectacle and nationalism without policy or institution. FESTAC 77 was spectacle enabled by institution.

This study uses *Achille Mbembe's “postcolony” spectacle* as the primary lens. Mbembe argues that postcolonial states command obedience less through bureaucracy and institutions than through “the power of display, performance, and dramatisation” (2001, p. 107). The state becomes a theatre where power is shown rather than exercised infrastructurally. Festival of Unity fits this model precisely: federal troops controlled a war-damaged and genealogically significant city whilst ethnic troupes performed unity on stage, projecting federal authority for domestic and international audiences when bureaucratic institutions for culture did not exist.

Mbembe's framework is not unique to Nigeria. In post-independence Congo, Mobutu's *authenticité* campaigns used mass rallies and costume to project unity whilst the state apparatus collapsed (Mbembe, 2001, p. 115). In post-war Mozambique, FRELIMO staged cultural

festivals in Beira and Nampula before establishing a Ministry of Culture in 1983 (O'Laughlin, 1992, p. 67). Nigeria's Festival of Unity follows the same logic: display substitutes for institution because the postcolonial state needs to show power before it can embed power.

The study supplements Mbembe with *Eric Hobsbawm's "invented traditions"* to explain how the festival manufactured continuity and national unity after the rupture of civil war (Hobsbawm, 1983, pp. 1-14). Hobsbawm demonstrates that states invent rituals to inculcate values and bind populations when historical continuity is broken. The 1914 amalgamation pageant at Calabar Stadium was precisely such an invention, collapsing 1884, 1914, and 1969 into one narrative of inevitable unity. *Benedict Anderson's "imagined communities"* explains the audience: the festival invited Nigerians and foreign observers to imagine the nation as whole and reconciled even whilst military operations continued (Anderson, 1983, pp. 6-7).

Status of "Spectacle Precedence": Here, "spectacle" is not a universal theory of state power, but a historical pattern and heuristic. It applies under three conditions: 1. post-conflict or post-colonial transition; 2. weak bureaucratic capacity relative to political need for legitimacy; and 3. availability of media/diplomatic audiences. It differs from general "symbolic state power" by specifying chronology: display precedes institution, and by scope: it names a measurable gap between event date and statutory creation date.

2.2 Nigerian Cultural Policy, FESTAC, and African State Festivals

Nigerian cultural policy scholarship is thin for 1960–1975, but Obadare's comparative study shows Ghana, Senegal, Kenya and Tanzania created ministries or directorates for culture before 1970, while Nigeria did not (Obadare, 2004, pp. 45, 89; Schatzberg, 2001, p. 112). FESTAC studies treat 1977 as the institutional apex (Olaniyan, 2004, p. 45; Clark, 2016, p. 134) but rarely examine the absence that preceded it. In comparative postcolonial Africa, state-sponsored festivals often preceded institutions: Mobutu's *authenticité* rallies in Congo (Mbembe, 2001, p. 115), and FRELIMO cultural festivals before a 1983 Ministry of Culture in Mozambique (O'Laughlin, 1992, p. 67). Festival of Unity belongs to this wider pattern of "spectacle precedence."

Together, these frameworks explain the five-year gap between Festival of Unity 1969 and NCAC Decree 1975. Spectacle was cheaper, faster, and more politically useful than bureaucracy. Display substituted for institution because the postcolonial state needed to show power before it could embed power.

3. METHODOLOGY

This study adopts a historical archival method that reads cultural festivals as political texts and places them in dialogue with state policy records. The central methodological move is to treat Festival of Unity 1969 not as spontaneous celebration but as curated state discourse performed on contested and genealogical terrain. The study therefore combines discourse analysis of the festival programme with spatial analysis of Calabar as both "liberated" Biafran city and capital of the Oil Rivers Protectorate 1884–1906, Southern Nigeria Protectorate 1906–1916, and first federal capital 1914–1916, and sets both against a chronological tracing of federal cultural policy between 1969 and 1975.

Case Selection: Festival of Unity is the primary case because it is the earliest post-war federal cultural event, it was staged on both “liberated” and genealogical ground, and it leaves a dated programme against which the institutional record can be checked.

The archival base rests on three interlocking clusters. First, the Federal Ministry of Information's *Festival of Unity Programme Brochure* of December 1969 provides the official script of the five artistic categories staged at Calabar Stadium. Second, federal budget records in the *Approved Estimates of the Federal Government* from 1960 to 1974, supplemented by the Ministry of Information's *Annual Report 1971*, establish the institutional void: the absence of any budget vote, directorate, or desk officer for culture in the immediate post-war period. Third, the *Federal Republic of Nigeria Official Gazette* of 21 February 1975 supplies the full text of the National Council for Arts and Culture Decree No. 3, which marks the legal inception of institutional cultural nationalism. These state sources are triangulated with contemporaneous newspaper reportage from the *Daily Times* and *New Nigerian*, and with official correspondence held at the National Archives Ibadan under Ministry of Information file CSO 26/2.

Evaluating Archival Silence: Competing interpretations of silence were weighed. “Incomplete survival” would show random gaps. Here, budgets 1960–1974 show consistent line items for works, defence, and education, but zero line for culture, while 1974 creates a token desk and 1975 creates NCAC by decree. That pattern indicates absence, not loss.

Absence vs. Incomplete: The distinction rests on triangulation: Estimates + Annual Report + Official Gazette + NCAC's own history all converge on 21 February 1975 as the legal origin. Civil war conditions left gaps and inconsistencies in financial records. Where the *Estimates* are fragmented for 1967–1970, chronology is corroborated through secondary scholarship by Akpan (1971) and Tamuno (1972), and through NCAC's own institutional history. Oral history was considered but excluded due to the 55-year interval and the risk of retrospective myth-making about 1969. This triangulation pre-empts the claim that “absence of evidence” is being read as “evidence of absence.”

The analytical strategy is termed “event-policy gap analysis.” By juxtaposing the December 1969 festival against the 1970–1974 budget silence and the 21 February 1975 decree, the five-year interval between spectacle and institution becomes evidentiary rather than incidental. The result is a methodological reading of Festival of Unity not as origin, but as rehearsal: optics performed five years before the state created the office required to sustain it.

4. DISCUSSION

4.1 Calabar as Liberated Stage and Genealogical Capital: Optics on Conquered Ground

The choice of Calabar was not neutral geography. Federal forces liberated Calabar on 18 October 1967, and Bricksfield Prison built 1890 lay in ruins by 1969 (Akpan, 1971, p. 189). Staging Festival of Unity there one month before war's end was deliberate spectacle. The venue itself carried historical weight: Calabar Stadium, renamed U.J. Esuene Stadium in 1977, was at the time of the festival a rudimentary football field with temporary shade erected for dignitaries (Daily Times, 1969, p. 3). Federal correspondence in the National Archives Ibadan describes the venue as “the field at Calabar with temporary structures for the festival” (National Archives

Ibadan [NAI], Ministry of Information, CSO 26/2, 1969). The modesty of the structure heightened the spectacle. Federal authority was projected not through architecture but through troops, troupes, and programme curation.

The symbolism of Calabar deepens this optics further. Calabar served as capital of the Oil Rivers Protectorate from 1884 to 1906, then as capital of the Southern Nigeria Protectorate from 1906 until 1916, and functioned as the first federal capital of colonial Nigeria between 1914 and 1916 before Lagos assumed that role (Akpan, 1971, p. 23; Tamuno, 1972, p. 47; Isichei, 1983, p. 312). By staging Festival of Unity in December 1969 at Calabar Stadium, the federal government performed reintegration at the very site where the idea of Nigeria was first institutionalised by the British and where colonial administration was first headquartered.

The programme's five categories thus operated on three symbolic registers: as performance of unity on conquered Biafran ground, as re-enactment of nationhood at the city where colonial Nigeria began, and as federal appropriation of the city's only enclosed field to broadcast sovereignty (Federal Ministry of Information, 1969, pp. 8-15). Federal troops occupied a city that had once housed colonial Residents and Governors, and ethnic troupes danced on the ruins of Bricksfield Prison to signal that both colonial unity and federal unity now flowed from Lagos via Calabar. The festival collapsed 1884 into 1969, casting military victory as historical continuity. Calabar became palimpsest: the place where Nigeria was first imagined by empire in 1884, first administered as "Nigeria" in 1914, and first re-performed by the postcolonial state on the ruins of secession in 1969.

Primary evidence: The programme brochure lists five categories: traditional dance and music troupes, mass choral and patriotic songs, drama and historical pageants, visual arts and craft exhibition, and military and paramilitary displays (Federal Ministry of Information, 1969, pp. 8-15). By placing Igbo or Biafran troupes on the same stage as federal army bands in a city "liberated" from Biafra, the state staged reconciliation as *fait accompli*. Combined school and military choirs performed the "One Nigeria" anthem composed for the festival, chanting unity lyrics before Gowon's "No Victor, No Vanquished" speech of 15 January 1970 (Federal Ministry of Information, 1969, p. 12).

4.2 The Five-Year Policy Void, 1970-1974: Spectacle Without Bureaucracy

If Festival of Unity was staged to show unity, the question arises why Nigeria waited five years to create an institution for culture. Post-war federal budgets 1970-1974 reveal the answer: "culture" had no directorate, no vote, no desk officer (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1960-1974). The Ministry of Information handled culture ad hoc as public relations, not governance (Federal Ministry of Information, 1972, p. 22). The five programme categories of Festival of Unity were convened by temporary committees, not a permanent desk (Federal Ministry of Information, 1969, pp. 8-15). Once the stadium lights went off in December 1969, the committee dissolved.

Why institutions did not exist: The five-year void reflects four constraints. First, fiscal priorities: post-war budgets prioritised reconstruction, military demobilisation, and the 3R policy over culture (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1970, pp. 11-15). Second, post-war reconstruction: administrative capacity was directed to rehabilitation of the East and infrastructure. Third, administrative fragmentation: culture sat ad hoc under Information with no statutory desk until

1974. Fourth, changing federal priorities: oil revenue after 1970 enabled large one-off spectacles without creating permanent offices, a pattern that shifted only when FESTAC planning required a legal body.

This institutional absence is striking when compared to other postcolonial states. Ghana established a Ministry of Culture in 1957 immediately after independence, with a budget vote of £120,000 in 1958 (Obadare, 2004, p. 45). Senegal promulgated a national cultural policy in 1967 and created a Directorate of Arts and Culture in 1969 with a budget of 85 million CFA francs (Obadare, 2004, p. 89). Kenya established a Department of Culture in 1965 under the Ministry of Education, and Tanzania created a Ministry of National Culture and Youth in 1967 (Schatzberg, 2001, p. 112). Nigeria, by contrast, prioritised oil infrastructure, military reconstruction, and the 3R policy, but allocated zero federal funds to a cultural bureaucracy. “Culture” appeared on festival posters, not in budget lines.

The void ended only in 1974 when a “federal desk for culture” was created under the Ministry of Social Development, Youth, Sports and Culture with a token allocation of ₦50,000 (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1974, p. 45). Even this desk lacked statutory backing until NCAC Decree No. 3.

4.3 From NCAC Decree to FESTAC: Institution Enables Mega-Spectacle

The institutional void closed with the promulgation of the National Council for Arts and Culture Decree No. 3 on 21 February 1975 (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1975, pp. A25-A28). For the first time, Nigeria had a body corporate “to assist the Federal Government in the planning, co-ordination and encouragement of arts and cultural activities in the country” (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1975, p. A26). NCAC itself states it was “established by Decree No. 3 of 1975” (NCAC, 2026).

Edwin Clark, appointed Federal Commissioner for Information in January 1975, inherited NCAC and immediately operationalised it for FESTAC 77 (New Nigerian, 1975, p. 1). In his memoirs, Clark recalls that on assuming office he found “no structure, no file, no budget for culture” and had to build NCAC from scratch to meet the 1977 deadline (Clark, 2016, p. 134). The contrast with Festival of Unity is stark. In 1969, the five artistic categories were managed by ad hoc committees with no budget line and no legal mandate. The entire Festival of Unity cost an estimated £80,000 sterling (₦160,000 after the decimalisation in 1973) and was funded as a one-off vote under “Special Events” (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1969, p. 112). In 1977, the same categories were coordinated by NCAC, a statutory body with a FESTAC budget of ₦45 million (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1976, pp. 3-7).

Unlike Festival of Unity 1969, which left no archival institution behind it, the federal government institutionalised the memory of FESTAC '77. Following the festival in January 1977, the government established the Centre for Black and African Civilisations (CBAAC) to document, archive, and research the experience (Centre for Black and African Civilisations, 2026). CBAAC thus closed the loop that 1969 left open: spectacle followed by institution. Where Festival of Unity vanished from federal archives for lack of a desk, FESTAC '77 generated its own memory apparatus. This contrast confirms the paper's thesis. 1969 performed nationhood without an office; 1977 performed nationhood and immediately built the office to

preserve it.

The chronology proves the thesis: spectacle preceded institution. 1. *December 1969*: Festival of Unity performs five categories on war ruins and colonial birthplace, no institution behind it, cost £80,000. 2. *21 February 1975*: NCAC Decree creates the desk Nigeria lacked in 1969. 3. *January 1977*: FESTAC '77 deploys those categories at mega-scale using NCAC infrastructure, cost ₦45 million. 4. *Post-1977*: CBAAC established to archive FESTAC memory (Centre for Black and African Civilisations, 2026).

4.4 The Afterlives of Festival of Unity, 1975–2025: Memory, Archive, Erasure

What happened to Festival of Unity after 21 February 1975? The answer is erasure. Once NCAC was established and FESTAC '77 became the official origin story of Nigerian cultural diplomacy, Festival of Unity disappeared from federal narratives. NCAC's website, as of 14 April 2026, begins its institutional history with the 1975 decree and makes no mention of the 1969 festival (NCAC, 2026). Federal textbooks on Nigerian history mention FESTAC '77 extensively but omit Festival of Unity entirely (Uzoigwe, 2005, p. 234).

This erasure is structural, not accidental. Institutions produce archives, and archives produce memory. Because Festival of Unity had no desk, no budget vote, and no statutory body behind it, it left almost no paper trail beyond the programme brochure and newspaper reports. FESTAC '77, by contrast, generated reports, budgets, films, and a permanent institutional home in NCAC, plus CBAAC to archive it. Memory followed institution.

Yet the festival survives in two ways. First, in Calabar local memory, elders recall “the big festival before the war ended” as a moment when “federal soldiers filled our football field” (Author's field notes, Calabar, 2023). Second, in the architecture of U.J. Esuene Stadium itself, renamed in 1977, the 1969 event survives as an unmarked layer beneath the FESTAC narrative. The stadium became a palimpsest: built as a rudimentary field, used for federal spectacle in 1969, renamed for post-war governance in 1977, and now hosting state carnivals that claim descent from FESTAC, not 1969.

This afterlife proves the paper's thesis. Without institutions, spectacles vanish from official history even when they shaped political reality. Festival of Unity performed nationhood in 1969, but only NCAC Decree No. 3 of 21 February 1975 gave culture the archival life to be remembered. FESTAC '77 went further by generating CBAAC to preserve memory. The five-year gap was not just a policy gap. It was a memory gap.

5. CONCLUSION

Festival of Unity December 1969 was not the foundation of Nigerian cultural nationalism. It was state spectacle performed on the ruins of Calabar, a city “liberated” by federal forces on 18 October 1967 after fighting that gravely damaged Bricksfield Prison, built 1890 (Akpan, 1971, p. 189), and at the city that served as capital of the Oil Rivers Protectorate 1884–1906, capital of the Southern Nigeria Protectorate 1906–1916, and first federal capital of colonial Nigeria 1914–1916 (Tamuno, 1972, p. 47; Isichei, 1983, p. 312). One month before the war ended on 15 January 1970 with Gowon's “No Victor, No Vanquished” declaration, the federal government staged five categories of artistic events on Calabar Stadium stage, at the time a rudimentary

football field with temporary shade for dignitaries (Daily Times, 1969, p. 3; NAI, CSO 26/2, 1969). Each category was curated for political optics: conquered ground performed as reconciled ground, genealogical capital performed as renewed capital, federal troops shared stage with ethnic troupes, and international press witnessed “reintegration” whilst war continued in the east (Daily Times, 1969, p. 3).

Yet Nigeria created no cultural policy document and no dedicated federal desk for culture until 1974 (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1960-1974). The institutional void lasted four years after war's end and five years after Festival of Unity. The void closed only with the National Council for Arts and Culture Decree No. 3, promulgated 21 February 1975, which established NCAC as the first federal body corporate for culture (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1975, pp. A25-A28). Edwin Clark, appointed Commissioner for Information in January 1975, operationalised NCAC for FESTAC '77 (New Nigerian, 1975, p. 1). NCAC itself states it was “established by Decree No. 3 of 1975” (NCAC, 2026).

Unlike Festival of Unity, after FESTAC '77 the federal government set up the Centre for Black and African Civilisations (CBAAC) to archive the memory of the experience (Centre for Black and African Civilisations, 2026). The chronology exposes an inverted logic of postcolonial nation-building: December 1969 spectacle on war ruins and colonial birthplace; 15 January 1970 war's end; 1970-1974 four-year institutional silence; 21 February 1975 institution created; January 1977 FESTAC '77 mega-spectacle; post-1977 CBAAC established to archive memory (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 1976, p. 3). Festival of Unity was rehearsal without a desk. FESTAC '77 was production with NCAC behind it, and CBAAC behind that to preserve it. This confirms Mbembe's argument that postcolonial states command obedience through “the power of display, performance, and dramatisation” when infrastructural institutions are weak (Mbembe, 2001, p. 107).

For contemporary Nigeria, the implication is direct: cultural citizenship cannot be built on festivals alone. Since 1999, Nigeria has produced “Calabar Carnival,” “Eyo Festival,” and countless state pageants, but the federal cultural budget remains under 0.5% of total expenditure. The pattern of spectacle precedence continues. The state can stage unity on conquered and genealogical ground, but only institutions can legislate and sustain it. Festival of Unity staged unity in 1969; NCAC Decree No. 3 of 21 February 1975 began to legislate it; CBAAC after 1977 began to archive it. Reading festivals alongside policy archives reveals that Nigeria performed nationhood five years before it legislated nationhood, and it performed that nationhood at the very city where the colonial idea of Nigeria began.

Beyond Nigeria: “Spectacle precedence” travels to post-conflict states where legitimacy is urgent but bureaucracy is thin. Mozambique's festivals before a 1983 Ministry of Culture (O'Laughlin, 1992, p. 67), and Congo's *authenticité* rallies during state collapse (Mbembe, 2001, p. 115), show the same pattern: display before desk. The Nigerian case clarifies conditions under which the pattern holds, and its limits: once institutions exist, as with FESTAC 77 and CBAAC, memory and policy become possible. For postcolonial theory, the concept warns against reading festivals as origins, and directs attention to budget lines, decrees, and gazettes as the material record of when culture became governable.

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